

Homeric Religion: The Gods and the Poet

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Summary

The epics that are associated with Homer's name, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, emerge from a long tradition of oral song that extends back into the Late Bronze Age. The poems themselves, however, date from the late 8th or early 7th centuries BC. From the perspective of religious belief and religious practice, the society that is described in these epics, like the society of the 8th and 7th century Aegean world, is a polytheistic society: the heroes within the epics, like the audiences themselves of that epic tradition, worship not one but a number of gods. The gods of the epics, such as Zeus, Hera, Athena, Apollo, and Aphrodite, are, however, remarkably vivid, in that they have not only been intensely personalized, being endowed with humanlike form and appearance, but also socialized. These gods are portrayed as a family that lives together on Mount Olympus, where they are embedded in a complex web of interpersonal relationships. And yet, despite their divine status, the gods of epic mingle with the race of heroes on earth; indeed, when they choose, they are key players in human affairs. On occasions the gods behave in ways that, to another culture, might appear undignified or ridiculous--ungodly; but, for the most part, they presented as powerful figures, and at times terrible.

To turn from theology of belief, as represented in the Homeric epics, to the theology of religious practice, it will become clear from the discussion below that the Homeric account of religious practice is different in some respects from the religious practice of the archaic Greek world; what is observable is that the epic tradition has omitted from its account of religious practice a number of elements important to worshippers in the real world, such as divination through the consultation of entrails or rituals of fertility. And a certain poetic stylization of presentation has made some real-world practices less recognizable. More recently there have been fruitful attempts to identify elements of religious belief and practice that can be traced back in time to the wider Bronze Age world. At the same time, too, scholars have reflected on the gods' role in the epic as participants in and observers of the action.

Keywords: Olympian gods; fate; divine justice; worship; prayer; supplication; sacrifice; libation; reciprocity; Homer; *Iliad*; *Odyssey*; Homeric gods; afterlife

The Gods of Epic: Aegean Bronze Age Traditions and Influence from the Near East

Many of the ideas about the gods that are found in the epics had for some time been attributed to the poet himself or to the tradition he worked in; for, indeed, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* offer us the first integrated account of Greek perceptions of their gods.¹ The decipherment of Linear B in the 1950s, however, along with sophisticated studies of Near Eastern polytheistic religions and epic poetry, have thrown new light on Homeric religion.² From the perspective of the early 21st century it is clear that the Homeric representation of religious belief and practice draws on older traditions from the Aegean world; but it cannot be completely aligned with the picture that can now be derived from archaeological, linguistic, and epigraphic evidence of the lived experience. New evidence reveals that the representation of the gods of the Homeric epics has been animated to some extent by contact with the religions of west Asia (more commonly described as the Near East) and that the representation of religious

belief and religious practice that is observed in these poems has somewhat more to do with the traditions of epic than with the realities of life.³

The epic tradition that is associated with Homer, like the traditions in the Near East, developed and elaborated a particular concept of the gods, giving each divinity his or her own personality and a select range of preferences. And, simultaneously, it engaged in a simplification or stylization of many aspects of religious practice. These choices are, of course, understandable. A storyteller working in an oral epic tradition would find many advantages in bringing divinities to life and allowing these divinities to play an active role in his tale. There are advantages as well in paring back elements of religious practice and ritual behaviour, not only in order to sharpen focus on the action of the tale but also, in practical terms, for compositional convenience. Thus an attentive reader of the epics might observe how the poet has adapted elements of religious belief and practice to serve his own narrative goals: some examples of these storytelling strategies are noted in the discussion below.

The Gods: Their Nature and Their Circumstances

A study of the gods of the Homeric epics must begin with a discussion of their nature as the poet described it. The primary characteristic of Homer's gods is their immortality. They are described by this tradition as ἀγήρω (ageless) and ἄθνατος (immortal) (*Il.*12.323; 17.444; cf. *Od.*1.31). Since they are immortal, it is clear that their physiology is in crucial ways different from that of mortals. In the first place, their veins flow with *ichor* (*Il.*5.339-340), the divine equivalent of human blood. And they sustain themselves not on the food and drink that sustains humankind but on immortal *ambrosia* (*Od.*5.93) and *nectar* (a divine liquid, *Il.*1.598; 4.3; *Od.*5.93). The gods, therefore, do not touch the (perishable) meat that mortals offer them by way of sacrifice; they simply partake of its savour (*Il.*1.315-317, 8.549). In this way, it is assumed, they avoid that cycle of growth and decay that is associated with being human. The gods are always in the prime of life; their energy is boundless (*Il.*15.355-359) and their physical powers are impressive: they can move with astonishing speed from place to place (*Il.*15.78-83), or from Olympus to earth (*Il.*4.73-79; 24.77-82, 93-97, 120-122; *Od.*1.102-103); when a god shouts, as Ares does, at *Il.*5.859-861, or Poseidon at *Il.*14.147-151, he or she can produce the equivalent of 9,000 or 10,000 voices.⁴

These gods had their origins in a variety of regions, at different times: Poseidon, Hera, Athena and possibly Hephaestus are thought to have been the gods of earlier inhabitants of the Peloponnese, before the ancestors of the Greeks arrived.⁵ Zeus, whose name is cognate with the Indo-European sky-god,⁶ appears to have Indo-European origins, appearing in Greece in the course of the migrations of the Aegean Bronze Age.⁷ Other gods were imported subsequently, at various points in time, from the cultures of Asia Minor and the Middle East, thanks perhaps to trade links between mainland Greece and the cultures of the Eastern Mediterranean.⁸ Thus Hades, the god of the Underworld, is an Asiatic adaptation, as are Aphrodite, Artemis, and Apollo.⁹ The Greeks believed that Dionysus entered the pantheon from elsewhere, possibly Asia Minor;¹⁰ Ares appears to have come from Thrace, to the north. All these gods, except Aphrodite, are attested, in some form, on Late Bronze Age Linear B tablets.¹¹ This evidence tells us that, with Aphrodite's possible exception, Homer's gods, in name at least, were also the gods of Late Bronze Age Greece.

It is uncertain how the people of the Late Bronze Age conceived of their gods: did they think of them as persons, as they appear in Homer? Or did they think of them in terms of their

functions? Or both? Thus, for example, Zeus may have been thought of both as a potent sky-god, the god of the weather and as a being similar to mortals, at least in form and in personality.¹³ Over time the gods acquired, in addition to their cosmological power, a different kind of authority, the power to intervene in human affairs. Two factors would have encouraged this development. First, conceptions of the gods of the Greek world may have been influenced by beliefs and attitudes from the eastern end of the Mediterranean: the gods of the Sumerians, for example, were thought to live as a family; they received sacrifice from humans; and they controlled their destinies.¹⁴ Second, one must take into account the development over the centuries of epic poetry, a tradition that responds to audiences' preference for stories about individuals and their actions. Epic singers drew on the gods as subject matter and created stories about them. Such stories would have encouraged further systematization of the gods, attributing to them their own divine language¹⁵ and, to each one, his or her own personality and perspectives.¹⁶ By the early archaic period, the period that saw the composition of the Homeric epics, these divine forces had been assembled into a single extended family, a complex of blood relationships of which the most remarkable feature is the closeness and multiplicity of kinship ties between each member, which in turn have led to firm alliances between some gods and jealousy, rivalry, and unhappiness between others. Although the idea of a family of gods is neither a Greek nor a Homeric invention, what distinguishes the divine family that audiences encounter in the epics is, as Burkert describes it, its 'clarity of organization'.¹⁷

The Divine Family

At the head of the family is Zeus. Homeric epithets recognize the family 'history' that lies behind his succession to this role: he is described both as 'son of Cronus' (*Il.*1.498; 16.440; *Od.*1.45) and as 'father of gods and men' (*Il.*1.544; *Od.*1.28). He is, he declares, the oldest and most powerful of the Olympians (*Il.*8.17; 15.165-167). Even the gods who are not his children address him as 'father' (*Il.*1.503). Zeus' association with weather is marked in the epithets 'cloud-gatherer' (*Il.*5.631; *Od.*5.21) and 'delighting in thunder' (*Il.*24.529; *Od.*7.164). The thunderbolt is his characteristic weapon. One of Zeus' characteristic symbols is his *aegis*, a garment or shield apparently made for Cronus by Hephaestus (*Il.*15.308-310). The *aegis* is not well described in the epics (cf. *Il.*2.447-449), but it offers divine protection (*Il.*24.20-21) and inspires terror in mortals (*Od.*22.297-298).

Zeus is 'far-seeing' (*Il.*1.498; *Od.*2.146); his judgment is impartial, as his use of his golden scales testifies (*Il.*8.69-72; 22.209-213).¹⁸ The force of his authority is revealed when he assents to Thetis' plea in *Iliad* 1, that he, Zeus, should ensure that the Achaeans regret the loss of Achilles, who has withdrawn from the fighting. When Zeus nods in consent, all Olympus is shaken (*Il.*1.528-530). As king of the gods, he is likewise patron of mortal kings: as Burkert notes, all sovereignty amongst men proceeds from Zeus.¹⁹ He has the power to determine the course of human affairs (*Il.*15.53-77; 16.644-655; 17.201-208; *Od.*1.76-79; and see further below), although not all the gods always endorse his decisions. He is the guarantor of oaths and protector of guests and suppliants (on which topics see 'The Gods' Oversight of Mortals' Behaviour', below). Zeus has numerous offspring, some divine (among them Aphrodite, Apollo, Ares, Artemis, Athena, Dionysus, and Hermes) and some mortal (among them Dardanus, Helen, Hercules, Minos, and Sarpedon). A number of his grandsons fight on the Trojan Plain, but only one of his sons does so: Sarpedon, whose death Zeus mourns with tears of blood (*Il.*16.459-461).

Zeus' brothers are Poseidon, the god of the sea and earthquakes, and Hades, the god of the Underworld (*Il.*15.187-192). Zeus' sister—and wife—is Hera (*Il.*4.58-61). As Homer portrays her, Hera is a prickly individual in her relationships with others: in the *Iliad* she is demanding, prone to jealousy, and devious (*Il.*1.531-570; 14.153-360). But she was powerful nevertheless: she was regularly accorded great honour in cult-worship in the Greek world. Zeus and Hera's son, Hephaestus, the god of fire, is the divine smith (*Il.*1.571, 577; 18.369-379); another son, Ares, is the god of slaughter and war (*Il.*5.889-898). Athena, also a child of Zeus—but of Zeus alone—and a fearless warrior who appears in the epics more than any other god except Zeus, represents good judgment (*Il.*1.193-222) and inventive thought (*Il.*5.59-61; 9.390; *Od.*13.361-379, 395-405); Apollo and Artemis are the children of Zeus and Leto (*Il.*1.9; 21.502-504). Apollo, known for his music, has the capacity to bring disease (*Il.*1.43-52) and to heal it (*Il.*1.456-457); his attributes are the lyre (*Il.*1.603) and the bow (*Il.*1.44-45). Artemis is portrayed in Homer as always a (rather flighty) girl (*Il.*21.470-496), who, like Apollo, can bring disease (*Il.*24.605-607). Hermes, the son of Zeus and Maia, is, like Iris (*Il.*3.121), a guide and messenger (*Il.*24.334-469; *Od.*5.28-148); but, unlike Iris, he can also cross the boundary between living and dead (*Od.*24.1-14). 'Golden' Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus and Dione, represents love and desire. Her realm is not married love (that is Hera's domain); Aphrodite is concerned with passion (*Il.*14.198-199). Her husband was Hephaestus, as the *Odyssey* tells it; but the poem includes the story of an affair that she had with her half-brother Ares (*Od.*8.266-366). Absent from this divine household, at least as far as Homer's main narrative suggests, are Demeter (a one-time partner of Zeus) and Dionysus, son of Zeus. Included, however, in the theology of the epics are divinities who don't belong to the divine family which resides on Olympus. These beings are not gods in the sense that Olympian Zeus and Hera are gods; these lesser gods have supernatural powers, but they are much lower in a notional divine hierarchy and are subject to Olympian will.²⁰ Included in this lower division of gods are Achilles' mother Thetis, a sea-goddess, daughter of Nereus, the Old Man of the Sea (*Il.*1.351-435, 556; 18.35-53); Circe, daughter of Helios (*Od.*10.135-139); and Calypso, daughter of Atlas (*Od.*1.51-52; 5.13-15). Also on the fringe are the Erinyes, dread goddesses who punish certain crimes, including perjury (*Il.*19.259-260); these gods have a long history, as Linear B tablets from Knossos attest.²¹

Divine Residences

With the exception of Hades (whose permanent residence was the Underworld), the divine family was thought to live at least some of the time, remote and untroubled, on the peak of one of the loftiest mountains in northern Greece, cloud-circled Mount Olympus (*Il.*1.493-499, 605-611; *Od.*6.41-46). Here too they would meet in council, over which Zeus presided (*Il.*4.1-4).²² The gods' homes on Olympus are in every way resplendent, as anything associated with the divine was thought to be (*Il.*14.166-168; 20.10-12). Agelessness and immortality extend to everything associated with these gods: their belongings, their weapons, their armour, their horses, their chariots--and their dwellings--are without flaw, imperishable, and splendid (consider, for example, Hera's chariot at *Il.*5.720-731). The epics tell us that the gods individually, with the notable exception of Zeus, favoured certain cities and localities in the Greek world, which they would sometimes visit, absenting themselves from Olympus. So, for example, Poseidon had homes at Onchestus, Helice, Aegae, and Pylos; Aphrodite had a home on Cyprus; Apollo was thought to reside also at Chryse, Cilla, and Tenedos, Delos, Delphi, Ismarus, and Ithaca; and Hera at Argos, Mycenae, and Sparta.²³ Although these localities appear to correspond to the realities of cult-worship amongst the Greeks, there is no reference in the poems either to the cults themselves or, with one possible exception, to local festivals.²⁴ The Homeric poet makes it clear that these local associations are transcended in

the epic tradition: thus Hera, in the storyworld of the *Iliad*, would be prepared to see her cult-centres Argos, Mycenae and Sparta destroyed at some point, provided that Troy, for which she has implacable hatred, falls at once (*Il.*4.51-54).

Gods and Men

There was once a time in the past, the Homeric epics suggest, when gods mingled freely with mortals, just as, early on in the story of the *Iliad*, they visited the Ethiopians to feast with them (*Il.*1.423-425). But, even in the epic present, gods are prepared on occasion to engage directly with mortals: Athena appears to Achilles (*Il.*1.194-222); Aphrodite comes to the rescue of her son, Aeneas, and is wounded by Diomedes (*Il.*5.311-354); later in the same contest Athena stirs Diomedes once more to fight and enters the fray as his charioteer (793-861); Apollo enters the fray and strikes Patroclus on the back (*Il.*16.786-806); Iris appears before Priam with a message from Zeus (*Il.*24.169-188); and Hermes announces himself to Priam (*Il.*24.460-461). On those occasions the gods have appeared to mortals as divinities; on the other hand, there are numerous occasions when one or another of the gods descends to earth and, assuming a disguise, advises or encourages individual heroes when they are in difficulties.²⁶

The gods may be deeply interested in the affairs of men; but this interest is not all-consuming. The gods can be passionate observers of the fighting on the Trojan Plain; they can spur on their favourites, some of whom indeed are their offspring; they may weep for them when they lose; and they may be violent in their hatred of their opponents (*Il.*4.34-36; 8.350; 16.431-438, 459-460; 22.166-172).²⁷ They can use mists and clouds and darkness to protect their favourites—or to confuse their enemies (*Il.*17.268-271, 649-650; 18.239-242; 20.321-322; 21.596-598). But these gods can just as easily turn away. For the most part, the Olympian gods remain majestically detached, aloof from mere mortals: for them the activities of the race of men, even the race of heroes, is a source of entertainment, a spectacle that they might choose to watch (*Il.*4.1-4, 9-10; 7.58-61; 8.49-52; 20.22-23)—only occasionally is it more than that.²⁸ Despite the fact that some of the Olympian family support the Achaeans and some support the Trojans, there is, in their view, no point in coming to blows over mere mortals: they are not a vital concern for the gods.²⁹

The Gods, Chance Events, and Human Motivation

From the perspective of the poet, and of the world of men depicted in the epics, nothing happens by accident or as a result of random chance, whether the events in question are on a smaller or a larger scale. Every unusual occurrence in the epics is attributed to the gods: when a hero experiences a sudden surge of strength or speed, it is a god who has given him that power (*Il.*23.770-772); when Hector takes the top off Ajax's spear, Ajax knows that it was the gods' work (*Il.*16.114-121). The gods are believed to permeate the epic world.

Human motivation, on occasion, may be driven or, indeed, moderated by the gods. For example, when Pandarus breaks the truce between the Trojans and the Achaeans, the poet explains that Pandarus acted thus because Athena had promised him glory (*Il.* 4.86-104). Likewise, when Achilles draws his sword against Agamemnon in the course of their quarrel, the poet tells how Athena pulls at his hair and warns him against following through with his present intention (*Il.*1.188-205). These are much more vivid accounts of each decisive moment than if the poet were to observe quite simply that Pandarus acted on impulse or that

Achilles, at the critical point, had had second thoughts. The poet has attributed to a divine power the motivations and reactions that might equally be attributed to human psychology.³⁰ Because the poet has dramatized the working out of these impulses and these responses the events themselves remain vivid in the memories of his audiences.

The Gods and Fate

On a larger scale it is clear that Zeus, the king of gods and men, has in mind an outline of events to come within the framework of the *Iliad*-story. This outline represents *both* Zeus' will (the so-called *Dios boulē*) *and* what is destined by fate (*Il.*1.5; 8.470-477; 20.15, 20-21; *Od.*1.86; 5.30; 8.81-82).³¹ Thus, in Book 15 of the *Iliad*, Zeus is able to set out for Hera in more or less accurate detail the course of events on the Trojan Plain from the moment when Hector is revived by Apollo and re-energized for warfare (*Il.*15.64-77). Zeus forecasts how, in retaliation for the death of Sarpedon, Hector will kill Patroclus; and he foreshadows that Hector will be killed in turn by Achilles, at which point the fall of Troy will become inevitable (*Il.*15.69-71):

And from then on I would make the fighting surge back from the vessels
always and continuously, until the Achaeans
capture headlong Ilion through the designs of Athena.³²

Within that larger schema Zeus keeps in view both the fixed events in the tradition (such as the fall of Troy) and the appointed moment for each mortal's death: these outcomes being encapsulated in the terms *aisa* or *moira* ('allotted portion', 'fate').³³ With respect to the lifespan of an individual hero, the metaphor of the spinning of a thread of life occasionally appears (*Il.*20.127-128).³⁴ It should be noted that *moira* and *aisa* determine the life-paths of gods as well as mortals.

Fate in the *Odyssey* has a similar scope: it encompasses not only the deaths of selected mortals but also certain key events in their lives, which happen to be fixed points in the inherited tradition. So the poet takes up the action of the *Odyssey* when 'in the circling of the years that very year came/in which the gods had spun for him his time of homecoming to Ithaca . . .' (*Od.*1.16-18). Indeed, in this context the poet makes an occasional but not consistent distinction between *aisa* and *moira*: when Hermes gives Zeus' message to Calypso regarding Odysseus' destiny, at *Od.*5.113-115, he uses the term *aisa* to refer to the hero's lifeline and *moira* to refer to the events along that lifeline.

Zeus knows what is to happen in the mortal sphere; he is the guarantor of cosmic order; and yet he too is subject to it.³⁵ At times he may appear to resist what is fated; but this reluctance is for dramatic purposes only—through it not only does the poet awaken and maintain suspense in his external audience but also, suggesting pathos, he directs his external audience's sympathies.³⁶ When, for example, Zeus sees that Hector and Achilles are about to engage in the one-on-one combat that will lead to Hector's death, he pities him, announcing to Hera that because of Hector's continuing piety he is tempted to snatch the hero out of the battle and rescue him (*Il.*22.168-176). Hera, who has never been sympathetic to the Trojans, protests (*Il.*22.179-180):

Do you wish to bring back a man who is mortal, one long since
doomed by his destiny (*aisa*), from ill-sounding death and release him?

Zeus promptly rejects the possibility he has raised (*Il.*22.183-185): to spare Hector would, in fact, run counter to all that he, Zeus, stands for. The Olympian gods have no desire to up-end the present system of *moirai*; it is this that gives them their power and authority.³⁷ And, besides, Hector must die at some point: this is his *moira*, his portion. As Athena in the *Odyssey* says to Telemachus (*Od.*3.236-238):

But death is a thing that comes to all alike. Not even
the gods can fend it away from a man they love, when once
the destructive doom (*moira*) of leveling death has fastened upon him.

It is this attachment to *moira* and *aisa*, to what is appropriate in the light of one's portion, that governs the gods' responses to any special pleading on any one mortal's behalf.

The Gods' Oversight of Mortals' Behaviour

All mortals and all gods must, each one, act within the bounds of their *moira*—their 'portion', their allocated destiny. The principal element of the gods' allocation is honour: they therefore demand respect from mortals; their authority, their divinity, is not to be challenged (as Niobe unwisely does *Il.*24.602-609). When mortals fail to honour the gods appropriately they will be punished. Zeus himself, in the poems, presides over three areas of human behaviour: as guardian of hospitality, as guardian of suppliants, and as the keeper of oaths. His honour will be slighted should a mortal fail to act appropriately.

Mortals in the epics make frequent reference to Zeus *Xeinios*, an allusion to his function as guardian of hospitality. Zeus (along with the other gods) protects strangers and guests; and he punishes those who do not, for this represents a failure of respect for Zeus. Menelaus asks Zeus, in his capacity as *Xeinios*, to punish Paris for having abused his hospitality and stealing his wife (*Il.*3.351-354). At *Il.*13.622-625 he rebukes the Trojans for having no respect for the wrath of Zeus *Xeinios*: it is this offence to the god that serves as the justification for the Achaeans' expedition against Troy (as Diomedes says at *Il.*9.49). In the *Odyssey*, Odysseus is supported by Athena as he exacts revenge on the suitors, who have failed to observe the reciprocal goodwill of guests in their host's domain (*Od.*13.383-396; 20.1-55; 22.205-276).

Occasionally overlapping with his function as guardian of hospitality is the god's function as guardian of suppliants. In response to the Cyclops' challenge, when he discovers Odysseus and some of his men in his cave, Odysseus claims that he and his men are suppliants (*hiketai*, *Od.*9.269). The hero points out that (270-271):

. . . Zeus the guest god, who stands behind all strangers with honors
due them, avenges any wrong toward strangers and suppliants.

The gods of the epics seem rather dilatory, however, in their responses to suppliants who call for aid and in their punishment of those who have harmed them.³⁸ The only prompt response of a god to Homeric supplication is illustrated at *Od.*5.447-450. Odysseus has been tossed by wind and waves for two days and two nights. Near the mouth of a river on Scheria he detects a possible safe landing. He prays to the river-god to accept him as a suppliant. The river at

once stays its current, stops the breaking waves, calms the waters before the hero, and admits him, now safe, to its channel (451-453).

A third observable function of Zeus in the epics is as a guardian of oaths.³⁹ When the Achaeans and the Trojans declare a truce before the duel of Menelaus and Paris, Agamemnon offers sacrifice and prayers to Zeus, Helios, and the Furies (the Erinyes), setting out the terms of the truce (*Il.*3.264-301). The two armies voice a final appeal to Zeus (298-301):

Zeus, exalted and mightiest, and you other immortals,
let those, whichever side they may be, who do wrong to the oaths sworn
first, let their brains be spilled on the ground as this wine is spilled now,
theirs and their sons', and let their wives be the spoil of others.

It will be the Trojans, through Pandarus, who break the oath; but the instigator of Pandarus' action happens to be none other than Zeus himself, who sends Athena to carry out his wish (*Il.*4.70-72). And, indeed, the king of gods and men does not punish the oath-breaker at once; the punishment will ultimately be the fall of Troy.⁴⁰

When Odysseus and his companions reach the island of the sun god Helios, the hero asks his men to swear an oath that they will not touch Helios' cattle (*Od.*12.297-303). Having sworn the oath, the men nevertheless slaughter some of the cattle and butcher them, making an offering to the gods. Helios at this point protests to Zeus. Helios is concerned not about the breaking of the oath but about the violation of his honour. He therefore demands recompense (377-383). Zeus, in response, also makes no reference to the oath broken; he promises punishment for Odysseus' companions (385-388). And divine justice is—in this case—administered.⁴¹

The Gods and the Defence of Justice amongst Mortals

Despite what mortals believe about divine oversight of human behaviour, the behaviour of the gods with regard to justice is unpredictable. The gods of the epics are more concerned with *moira*, with their portion of honour, than they are with the morality of mortals' behaviour.⁴² All that mortals can be certain of is that the gods will be angered by any failure to honour them appropriately or by any conscious or unwitting breach of the protocols of respect. Indeed, the only indication in the *Iliad* of Zeus' interest in justice amongst men occurs not in the narrative of the epic but within a remarkable simile, at *Il.*16.384-392. Here the poet describes the great roar generated by the Trojan horses as they race towards the city in terms of a mighty storm generated by Zeus in anger at the failures of men (384-388):

As underneath the hurricane all the black earth is burdened
on an autumn day, when Zeus sends down the most violent waters
in deep rage against mortals after they stir him to anger
because in violent assembly they pass decrees that are crooked,
and drive righteousness from among them and care nothing for what the gods think.

In the *Odyssey*, by contrast, the poet offers a stronger moralizing view; here one finds more frequent references to Zeus' concern to defend justice and punish wrongdoing (*Od.*1.32-34; 3.130-136). Bad behaviour in this epic is consistently linked to divinely sanctioned punishment.⁴³

Communication with the Gods: Worship, Gifts, and Prayer

The Homeric world was always alert to the gods' capacity to affect their surroundings and to intervene in their lives for good or ill.⁴⁴ For this reason, at least, it was obvious that these divine forces, these gods, must be venerated. They must be worshipped in the hope that they might bring about what is desirable and that they might forestall disasters large and small; and, should disaster strike, they must be propitiated with respectful words and with gifts. As Nestor's son Pisistratus says, 'all men need the gods' (*Od.*3.48). Furthermore, the gods far surpassed mortal man with regard to knowledge, especially knowledge of the future. Not only were they aware of what had been destined by fate, they also had the capacity to shape plans in order to achieve long-term goals; and they could oversee their fulfilment. Since mortals had no knowledge of what the future held, they turned to the gods in prayer, in order to put on the record their wishes and desires. On only one occasion in the epics do we observe a second form of consultation, a visit to an oracle, namely, Agamemnon's visit to Delphi ('sacred Pytho') at *Od.*8.79-80. This form of communication with the gods is barely recognized in the Homeric world.

Sacrifice and Other Offerings

The central act of worship in the epics is not an act of communal praise and supplication performed in a designated building or temple set aside for this very purpose (although temples are known in the world of Homer [*Il.*1.37-41], as are songs of praise dedicated to a god [*Il.*1.472-474]); nor did it take the form of a religious festival in honour of a particular god, a phenomenon which grew through the archaic age.⁴⁵ In the Homeric world the primary act of worship is sacrifice: principally, the sacrifice of a valuable animal, an ox, a sheep or a goat, or even a hecatomb (the offering of 100 oxen, if one takes the base meaning of 'hecatomb' literally--the Homeric heroes were not niggardly in their sacrificial calculations [see, for example, *Il.*1.65; *Od.*3.59]). Homeric offerings are almost exclusively animals: non-animal offerings such as grain and oil are unknown in this epic world.⁴⁶ Animal sacrifice, whether of one or more beasts, would necessarily be conducted outdoors. The epics do not mention the requirement for an altar, a holy table, or for sanctified implements for these ritual occasions, as was the case in later periods.⁴⁷

Who presides over these events? Here one finds a parallel with the city state of the classical world. Just as in the city-state a magistrate conducted sacrifice, so in the epics it is a senior male who officiates: Agamemnon conducts sacrifice in the presence of the Achaean army (*Il.*2.402-431; 3.271-301; 7.314-318; 19.249-268); and Nestor does so in Pylos, honouring Athena (*Od.*3.430-463). The only occasion on which a designated priest officiates is when, after the return of his daughter, Chryses offers sacrifice (the hecatomb brought for the purpose by the Achaeans) and prayers to Apollo, asking him to put a stop to the plague that he had sent upon the Achaeans (*Il.*1.450-456).⁴⁸

The ritual of sacrifice might be separated into 'pre-kill', 'kill', and 'post-kill' rites.⁴⁹ Of the pre-kill rites there are three attested--inconsistently--in the *Iliad*: handwashing (*Il.*1.449, 3.270), the scattering of barley (*Il.*1.449, 2. 410), and cutting the first hairs of the victim (*Il.*3.273; 19.254).⁵⁰ Homer's sacrificial animals are never garlanded or wreathed, as would be the case in large-scale sacrifices in classical Athens; there is no procession in which the sacrificial animal plays a leading role, nor is there any music; the animal is not said to be pelted with barley grains (although barley has a role in the rites [*Il.*2.421]), nor is there any

reference to the need to restrain the beast.⁵¹ As for the moment when the victim is killed, the Homeric poet recounts this briskly ('first they drew back the victims' heads and slaughtered them, . . .', *Il.*1.459). Rather, it is the details of subsequent butchering and food preparation that dominate the sacrifice ritual (skinning the animal; cutting meat from the thighs and searing it over a fire along with the entrails; putting the remaining meat on spits; and grilling it: *Il.*1.460-466; 2.421-431; *Od.*3.455-463, 470).⁵² The master of ceremonies himself is the butcher and cook—and he will be the carver as well.⁵³ The thigh pieces and the entrails, burned, represent the offering to the gods, who, it is hoped, will enjoy the pleasing savour of the smoke (*Il.*1.317; 4.48-49; 24.69-70). It was intended that the divine recipient would find particular pleasure in the victim chosen in his honour. At *Il.*24.68, for example, Zeus states that Hector 'never failed of gifts to my liking'; and, at *Od.*3.436-438, Nestor gilds the horns of the cow he is about to offer so that the goddess, Athena, 'might take pleasure in seeing the offering' [438]).⁵⁴

Sacrifice also served important social ends within the community. After due offerings have been made to the god (a modest proportion of the entire beast), those present would, in many cases, feast on the substantial remains.⁵⁵ The cooked meat was enjoyed by the hosts, by those who should be honoured (who might be given choice cuts),⁵⁶ and by those others who attended. The performance of sacrifice creates a bond between those present, even as it attempts to accumulate divine favour.

There are two occasions on which the poet introduces women into the ritual of worship. First, when Nestor's wife, daughters, and daughters-in-law give a ritual cry at the moment of slaughter, when Nestor sacrifices a victim to Athena (*Od.* 3.450-452). Second, when the women of Troy, through the mediation of Theano, the Trojan priestess, offer Athena a choice gown, and promise twelve heifers, asking the goddess to take pity on Troy, now hard pressed by the Achaean army (*Il.*6.297-311). In this case the immediate offering (to be made by the priestess herself) takes the form of women's handwork of the finest quality; sacrificial beasts, however, are promised, should the goddess show favour. What is notable here is that the priestess lays the gown over the knees of Athena's cult-image: a unique reference to a cult-image in the epics.

Libation

When an animal is sacrificed, wine is often poured in ceremonial fashion over the thigh pieces as they burn, as a drink offering to the gods--a libation (*Il.*1.462-463; 3.295-296; *Od.*3.459-460).⁵⁸ Libation plays a role in a social context as well: the first few drops of wine are regularly poured onto the ground as a prelude to drinking with guests and friends (*Od.*7.163-165, 179-181, 184). A libation often accompanies prayer, endowing that prayer with ritual solemnity (*Il.*3.295-296; *Il.*16.225-248). It accompanies oaths, for the same reason. And it precedes departure on a journey (as the Phaeacians farewell Odysseus on his journey back to Ithaca, *Od.*13.50-56); or on what is perceived as a dangerous mission (the departure of the Embassy to Achilles, *Il.*9.171-181; Patroclus' return to the battlefield, *Il.*16.225-248). A libation also, quite appropriately, may be made at the end of the day, to Hermes, the giver of sleep (as do the Achaeans at *Il.*9.712-713 and the Phaeacians at *Od.*7.136-138). It may honour the dead and the gods who dwell below: so, as a remarkable prelude to his encounter with the souls of the dead, Odysseus not only pours elaborate drink offerings for the dead, but also sacrifices a ram and a ewe, and promises a subsequent sacrifice on his return to Ithaca (*Od.*11.20-31).

Reciprocity

The giving up of something of value to the individual or the community is calculated to win the favour of the gods. Indeed, when food and drink are about to be shared, the gods are always designated as the first recipients, before all others. Thus they are marked out as special. And the gods were thought to recognize these marks of respect.⁵⁹ The performance of sacrifice may be associated with a special request, such as Chryses' request to Apollo to stop the plague (*Il.*1.447-456), or it may contribute to a credit 'account' to be drawn down at some time in the future (so Chryses had earlier reminded Apollo of the gifts he had offered to him over time, *Il.*1.39-42). Thus Aeneas' piety is recognized by Poseidon at *Il.*20.297-299. And Hector's piety is ultimately recognized when Apollo reproaches the gods who have resisted the rescue of his body from Achilles' continuing punishment: the god points out that Hector regularly burnt the thigh pieces of oxen and unblemished goats in their honour (*Il.*24.33-34). For this reason they should now make an effort to save him, so that his family can give him the proper burial rites. Zeus later reiterates the sentiment (68-70):

I loved him too. He never failed of gifts to my liking.
Never yet has my altar gone without fair sacrifice,
the smoke and savour of it, since that is our portion of honour.'

Odysseus' piety is similarly acknowledged by Zeus, when Athena in the *Odyssey* reminds him that Odysseus, 'who beyond others has given sacrifice to the gods', is yet to reach his homeland in the tenth year after the end of the Trojan War (*Od.*1.65-67). Gods and mortals alike understand that their relationship is based on the principle of reciprocity: nothing is given without some expectation of a return. Just as powerful members of a mortal community might be courted or to some degree placated or influenced by the giving of gifts by those around them, so too might the gods, who are acknowledged as all-powerful and in every way superior.⁶⁰ What mortals desired in return for their gifts was the goodwill of the gods, whether in the present or for the future. And the gods understood this principle and operated in accordance with it.

Reciprocity might equally be negative. When a mortal neglected to make sacrifice, this too was noted; and it was punished. In the course of the funeral games for Patroclus, when Teucer competes in the contest of the bow, he misses the mark because, as the poet tells us, he 'did not promise the lord of archery (Apollo) that he would accomplish for him a grand sacrifice of lambs first born' (*Il.*23.862-865). Likewise, the gods were offended when the Achaeans built a huge gated wall and a ditch between the plain of Troy and their ships. Poseidon protests that they did so without offering κλειτὰς ἑκατόμβας, 'splendid hecatombs' (*Il.*7.446-450, at 450). He argued too that this new wall would overshadow in its dimensions the great walls of Troy that he and Apollo had built for Laomedon (451-453). This double disrespect on the part of the Achaeans was in later times punished by the gods through the total obliteration of their construction (*Il.*12.1-35).⁶¹

Prayer

The expectation of reciprocity is often made clear in the formulation of Homeric prayers, which are offered when mortals need assistance beyond their own capabilities in order to ensure favourable outcomes or change the present course of events.⁶²

Prayers normally begin with an invocation of the god whom the speaker has identified as the most appropriate in present circumstances. The god will be addressed, possibly by several of his or her titles, which reflect his or her special local associations. The speaker's prudence and his sense of urgency lead him to list all possible divine locations. Thus Chryses prays to Apollo after he has been harshly dismissed by Agamemnon (*Il.* 1.37-39):

Hear me, lord of the silver bow, who set your power about Chryse
and Killa the sacrosanct, who are lord in strength over Tenedos,
Smintheus, . . .

Like so many speakers he proceeds to remind the god in question of his particular acts of piety and of the special claim he has on his or her favour (39-41):

. . . if ever it pleased your heart that I built your temple,
or if ever it pleased you that I burned all the rich thigh pieces
of bulls, of goats, . . .

Finally he spells out his request, briefly but carefully (41-42):

. . . then bring to pass this wish I pray for:
let your arrows make the Danaans pay for my tears shed.

It is notable that polite or oblique forms of the verb are not used in this context, despite the vast difference in status between the speaker and the addressee. The all-important criterion for the speaker at this stage of the prayer is clarity; there must be no mistaking his or her intention. For this reason those who pray resort to the directness of the imperative verb (so, in the *Iliad*, the Achaeans pray to Zeus before the single combat between Ajax and Hector: 'grant' (δός, *Il.* 7.203); 'give' (ῥάσσω, 205).⁶³ So Achilles prays for Patroclus' safety: 'send forth [glory] [with him]' (προές, *Il.* 16.241), 'make brave the heart inside him' (θάρσυνον, 242). And Priam prays for divine support: 'grant' (δός) and 'send' (πέμψον) at *Il.* 24.309-310.

Not all Homeric prayers are immediately preceded by sacrifice or libation; Nestor, on the battlefield, prays to Zeus as the Trojans surge forward towards the ships of the Achaeans. In the urgency of the moment he recalls earlier sacrifices to which, he claims, Zeus nodded favourably (*Il.* 15.372-376). Sometimes a request for immediate assistance may be accompanied by a vow to make an offering to the god at a later time: thus Pandaros, as he prepares to launch his arrow against Menelaus, promises 'a grand sacrifice' of first-born lambs to Apollo on his return to his homeland (*Il.* 4.119-121, at 120 = 101-103, at 102).⁶⁴ That arrow might have been fatal, but Athena stood by her favourite Menelaus and diverted it so that it simply grazed the hero's skin (4.127-129). Likewise, Eurylochus suggests to Odysseus' men that they should promise to build a temple to Helios as repayment for the cattle they propose to kill and eat (*Od.* 12.345-347).

Indeed, when a mortal is under severe pressure, even this reference to gifts offered in the past or past favours received may be omitted from his or her prayer.⁶⁵ In these cases the mortal relies implicitly on his or her continuing association with the god and the god's recollection of his piety. So Glaucus prays to Apollo for aid, after Sarpedon's death (*Il.* 16.514-526); Odysseus, whose close partnership with Athena is attested in both epics, prays to Athena as he sets out on his night mission with Diomedes (*Il.* 10.278-282) and again as he made one final sprint in the footrace at the funeral games for Patroclus (*Il.* 23.770):

Hear me, goddess; be kind; and come with strength for my footsteps.

Here the poet suggests that Athena and Odysseus are more like friends, or partners, than god and mortal suppliant. The instrumentalism of the earlier examples is in this case absent.

The Outcomes of Prayer

On many occasions a prayer to the gods will be answered favourably: so Chryses' prayer to Apollo is answered promptly, as Apollo directs his disease-bringing shafts against the beasts of the Achaeans and the men themselves (*Il.*1.43-52); and it is addressed equally promptly when he asks the god to 'beat aside' at last the plague (451-457). Priam's prayer to Zeus, for a successful mission to Achilles and for an immediate sign that might give him confidence in what he is about to undertake (*Il.*24.308-313), likewise receives a prompt response (314-321). And Odysseus' prayers to Athena, both before the night mission and in the course of the footrace in the funeral games, are heard with favour (*Il.*10.295; 23.771-772).

In the narrative of the epics the combination of sacrifice and respectful prayer achieves its ends--for the most part.⁶⁷ On some few occasions a prayer to the gods goes unanswered. A negative response to a prayer may mark a decisive moment, a turning point, in the narrative or it may point to its trajectory. So, when Agamemnon prays to Zeus for the destruction of Troy and the death of Hector before the day's end, Zeus accepts the sacrificial victims but refuses to fulfil Agamemnon's prayer; indeed he will pile up 'unwished-for hardship' for the Achaeans (*Il.*2.412-420). When the women of Troy offer Athena a splendid robe as a gift and, through Theano the priestess, pray to the goddess asking her to break Diomedes' spear and to 'have pity on the town of Troy, the Trojan women and their innocent children' (*Il.*6.297-310), the goddess 'nodded upwards' (311), the Greek gesture for refusal. When Achilles prays to Zeus, as he sends Patroclus back in to the fighting (*Il.*16.233-248), the poet tells us that Zeus heard him, granting one prayer (that Patroclus should beat back the assault on the Achaean ships) but refusing the other (that he should come safely out of the fighting) (249-252). And when Odysseus' men kill and eat some of Helios' cattle, after Eurylochus has promised repayment on their return home (*Od.*12.343-347), Helios does not acknowledge his declaration. Whereas the poet in each case makes his audience immediately aware that this is a decisive moment, he leaves the petitioners in ignorance; they will discover in time, and painfully, that the god has turned away. Indeed, it is the unwanted or unexpected outcome of an expressed desire, addressed in respectful terms to the gods, that makes a story such as that of the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* engaging.

Reading Divine Signs: The Practices of Divination and Prophecy

In the world the poet describes it is believed that the gods are prepared to give guidance to mortals about the future. When they wish to communicate with mortals they do so by various means: first of all, there is the channel of the spoken word. Gods may descend to earth to address men directly (Athena at *Il.*1.195-200; 2.166-181; Poseidon at 13.43-58, 95-124, 216-220, 231-239; 14.135-152; Apollo at 15.236-262; Athena at *Od.*1.105; 7.19-21; 13.221-225); they may appear to mortals in a dream (*Il.*2.5-36; *Od.*6.15-42). In both these cases it is more usual, although not the rule, that the god assumes a disguise: he or she may adopt the form and the voice of a person familiar, or at least unthreatening, to the addressee (at *Il.*13.43-58 Poseidon takes on the voice and form of the seer Calchas; at 216-220 of Thoas; at 14.135-152 he adopts the likeness of an old man; at *Od.*6.15-42 Athena appears as a childhood friend of

Nausicaa): it is important, of course, that men or women be reassured, not panicked, when the god addresses them; but, besides, these disguises are each assumed with the best chance of persuasion in mind.⁶⁸ Communications from the gods in disguise are almost always well received: the mortal addressed will act on the advice he or she has heard. Only Helen ventures to challenge the instructions of Aphrodite, disguised as a wool-dresser whom Helen knew from years past (*Il.*3.395-412). And now it is Aphrodite herself who chastises her sharply and brings her to heel.

On the other hand, gods may choose to send signs unaccompanied by speech: that is, signs that require interpretation. People of the Late Bronze Age, even into Roman times (and beyond), believed that gods sent omens to mankind to foreshadow events that lay in the future.⁶⁹ These omens generally, but not always, appeared in the sky--in the domain, that is, of the gods. It was the task of a seer to read a favourable or an unfavourable message into what they see: the flight of birds (*Il.*12.200-229; 13.821-823; *Od.*15.160-165, 525-528; 17.160); the crash of thunder or a flash of lightning (*Il.*2.353; 8.133-136; *Od.*20.103-104); or a sign to be read in a remarkable event: the appearance of a snake, for example, during the rituals of sacrifice (*Il.*2.308-320). In the context of epic these omens foreshadow the outcome of actions just completed or actions contemplated in the present. One form of divination, however, is absent from the epics: there is no consultation of the entrails of sacrificial animals here, as is familiar from later practices.

The man who performs religious offices in the *Iliad* is generally referred to as a *hiereus* (ἱερεύς) or *arētēr* (ἀρητήρ), terms which are generally translated as ‘priest’, but which literally mean, respectively, ‘one who sacrifices’ and ‘one who prays’: Chryses, for example, is described by both these terms [*Il.*1.11, 94, 370]; Theano, the priestess of Athena’s temple in Troy [*Il.*6.300], is a *hiereia* (ἱέρεια), one who sacrifices. Calchas, on the other hand, is most often described as a *mantis*, a prophet, seer, or augur (*Il.*1.62, 92, 106). This term (along with *theopropos* [*Il.*12.228], *oiōnistes* [*Il.*2.858], *oiōnopolos* [*Il.*6.76]) is the title accorded to the man who has the skill of reading signs sent by the gods. Like all craftsmen, *manteis* are acknowledged to be well versed in their skills (*Il.*1.384-385; 6.438; 12.228-229; *Od.* 1.202); the skill in prophecy is said to be attributed to Apollo (*Il.*1.71-72). Non-specialists, too, are thought to be able to read divine signs: as Odysseus (who is at an advantage in this case) does when Penelope tells him her dream (*Od.*19.555-558) of the eagle and the geese. He attempts (not entirely successfully, 560-569) to reassure his wife that the eagle (who declares himself to be Odysseus and who promises destruction of all the suitors) has given a clear prophecy, about which there is to be no doubt.

In the world of the *Iliad* it might appear that *manteis* are not consistently consulted or respected and that portents and bird signs are not consistently observed. At *Il.*12.211-229, Polydamas has urged Hector to have regard for what the narrator describes as a portent from Zeus, Hector replies (237-238, 243):

‘You tell me to put my trust in birds, who spread
their wide wings. I care nothing for these, I think nothing of them
One bird sign is best: to fight in defence of our country.

This intransigence of Hector has been included by the poet as a form of emphasis. It represents a moment of delusion on Hector’s part; it testifies to his determination against all advice--Polydamas’ and that of the gods—to continue the fight on the Trojan plain. And, of course, the poet will demonstrate that this is a bad decision on his part, a decision that will

lead to his death at Achilles' hands and, thereafter, to the fall of Troy. Hector's resistance to the import of what has been identified as a bird sign touches on a vital theological question: what counts as a sign from the gods? Underpinning Homeric theology is a kind of unspoken contract regarding divination: the gods must be prepared to offer signs to mortals; certain mortals must have the capacity to recognize and read them; and their communities must be prepared to accept those readings.

Death, Hades, and the Afterlife

Even in death mortals do not escape their gods. According to the epics, the soul (psūchē) of a mortal who has died leaves the light of the sun in the world above and descends, like a bird or a breath, to Hades (the realm that takes its name from its ruler), a dark and joyless region somewhere beneath the earth (*Il.*7.330; *Od.*3.410; 11.475-476).⁷⁰ This is the realm of the implacable god of the Underworld (*Il.*9.158-159). The soul begins its journey at the moment of death (*Il.*7.330; 16.856; 20.294; 22.362; 23.137; *Od.*3.410, 6.11, 10.560, 11.65, 475); but, as Patroclus' ghost notes, a soul cannot actually enter the gates of Hades until the funeral rites have taken place (*Il.*23.71-74). Likewise, Elpenor, who after his death became a stranded phantom, begs Odysseus to conduct funeral rites for him on his return to Circe's island at *Od.*11.60-78, so that he may enter Hades' realm.⁷¹

The ghost of Patroclus makes it clear that the souls of the dead are thought to *descend* to Hades, which is separated from the world above by gates and a river (*Il.*23.71-74). Odysseus in the *Odyssey* takes a different route, however, *crossing* land and sea (*Od.*10.508-515; cf. *Od.*24.11-14), until he reaches a point beyond the streams of Ocean. Odysseus must visit the Erebus, the realm of the dead, so that he can speak with Teiresias the seer, who will give him further instructions about his homeward journey. Erebus, with its meadow of asphodel, lies at the junction of two rivers, the Cocytus and the Pyriphlegethon, which flow into the river Acheron (*Od.*10.513-514; 11.539, 573). Here Odysseus sees the insubstantial shades of the dead (*Od.*11.34-43, 204-208). Some of these venture from the meadow to drink the blood that Odysseus spills in sacrifice, a pre-condition to his being able to communicate with them. Odysseus speaks with Teiresias, who, with the clarity of a seer, outlines the hero's *moira*: the hero hears instructions for his journey home and for what comes after, even the moment of his death (*Od.*11.100-137).

Although Circe tells Odysseus that the shades of the dead are nothing but 'shadows' (*Od.*10.495), the poet endows them with lively memories of their time on earth, along with the feelings and emotions that attended them there.⁷² Achilles in the Underworld reflects most bitterly on the fate of death; according to him, it is only in life—in any life—that 'existence' is meaningful (*Od.*11.488-491):

Shining Odysseus, never try to console me for dying.
I would rather follow the plough as thrall to another
man, one with no land allotted him and not much to live on,
than be a king over all the perished dead.

The Gods and the Poet

The religious context that the epics describe must be, at least to a certain degree, familiar and authentic, so that audience members can readily reconcile the divine world that the poet creates with their own; otherwise the force of each poem—the tragic force of the *Iliad* or the

moral force of the *Odyssey*--would be lost. But the poet, following the tradition that he has inherited, has pared back a number of aspects of religious practice that contemporary audiences would have known (public festivals such as the Panionian festival dedicated to Poseidon at Mycale near Smyrna [Hdt.1.148] and a range of rituals of fertility) in order to concentrate his focus on the gods and fate, those structures of religious belief that he makes crucial to his telling. He has not found it necessary to explore relations with the divine beyond prayer, libation, and sacrifice. Nor has he found it necessary to offer every detail of the religious practices that he chooses to describe: the rituals of sacrifice are a case in point.

The poems in different ways suggest the might and power of the Olympian gods: they foreground the gods' remoteness from human concerns; their physical prowess; their capacity for disguise; their capacity to influence events; their oversight of the behaviour of mortals; and their power to affect their lives.⁷³ These gods were not to be trifled with. They are deeply respected, therefore, by the heroes of the epic world. And yet these same gods are also presented, at other times, as frivolous, petty, argumentative, cunning, and disobedient.⁷⁴ The Homeric gods are colourful individuals; they are not uniformly august.

A number of scholars have viewed the divine apparatus of the epics as a less than reliable account of real world theology; they prefer to see it instead as a literary creation that provides both an entertaining backdrop to a heroic tale and a lively substitute for a psychological reading of human motivation.⁷⁵ Certainly, in portraying his divine family as inconsistently godlike,⁷⁶ the poet has to some degree, and for his own purposes, 'subordinated' the divine family to the race of men.⁷⁷ And the poet uses his divine family for other purposes as well: when the poet chooses to make his gods visible, whether in the *Iliad* or, to a much lesser extent, the *Odyssey*, they act as agents in helping achieve poetic ends, as has been noted; but they also act as an audience for the events around Troy.⁷⁷ Through this latter strategy the poet elevates the action on the plain to a new level. As occasionally passionate and interventionist spectators, the gods serve as mediators between the poet, the text, and its audiences: *their* responses guide readers and listeners towards the responses that the poet strives to evoke.⁷⁸

When Herodotus says that the poets Homer and Hesiod 'taught the Greeks the origin of the gods, gave the gods their titles, distinguished the honours due to them and their skills, and indicated their forms' (2.53), he is making a bold claim. The religion of the Homeric epics is, to be sure, recognizably a form of Greek religion: the pantheon of gods that is represented in the epics, the expectation in the epic world that the gods influence human destiny, the understanding that the gods interact in different ways with humans, the practices of worship, of animal sacrifice and libation, the channels by which gods and humans are believed to communicate, through prayers and oracles, and the belief in the survival of the soul in an afterlife all contribute to a complex system of religious practice that measures up in general terms to the beliefs and practices of the archaic and classical Greek world.⁷⁹ The epics offer us both an elaborated and, at the same time, an incomplete picture of those beliefs and practices. There are no healing cults and no mystery cults, no temple-cults, no consultation of entrails as a form of divination, no regularly-recurring rituals of fertility and no public festivals, all of which had been well established in the archaic period and all of which were part of life in the classical world.⁸⁰ And there are aspects that the poet, or his tradition, has stylized, with economy of detail as his goal: animal sacrifice as depicted in the epic is, for example, a much simplified version of the performance of ritual sacrifice that can be reconstructed from other evidence. The theology of the epics, therefore, is what Martin has described as a 'complementary blending'⁸¹ of cultural elements, a composite of older

traditions, traditions from the Near East, everyday belief and practice--and the epic world of the imagination.

Review of the Literature

There was a watershed period in the study of Greek religion, and likewise of Homeric religion: this was the decipherment of Linear B in the 1950s and the subsequent reading of tablets that had been discovered at principal Late Bronze Age sites across Greece.⁸² This material, along with the decipherment of a number of Near Eastern languages including Hittite and the insights gained therefrom, changed the landscape, so to speak, for the study of Homeric religion. The work of scholars writing before these significant breakthroughs is rich in commentary and source criticism, but the work itself is now in certain respects outdated. Thus the substantial volumes by Louis Gernet and Martin Nilsson on Greek religion are interesting for their sometimes idiosyncratic perspectives on the gods and on religious practice, but they are not useful for scholars today.⁸³

When Walter Burkert, however, in 1977 published his study of Greek religion in the archaic and classical periods—a work which continues to be influential—he was very ready to take account of the Mycenaean prehistory, the evidence of Linear B, the sources of influence in the Near East, and to acknowledge the basic compositional principle of oral epic, formulaic language. And, indeed, in that part of this important work devoted to the gods he is very ready to acknowledge the ‘spell of Homer’. For Burkert the gods were ‘human to almost the last detail’; he viewed them as a divine family, as the Homeric epics had presented them. For his contemporary, Jean-Paul Vernant, by contrast, the gods were abstractions; and the pantheon was a sociological system rather than an unruly family.

Research on Homeric religion at the end of the 20th century and into the 21st has followed three paths. First, one observes a continuity of research into the relationship between Near Eastern traditions and the theology of the Homeric epics. Sarah Morris’ survey, ‘Homer and the Near East’, is an important first step; Martin West’s *The East Face of Helicon* and *Indo-European Poetry and Myth*, along with Mary Bachvarova’s *From Hittite to Homer*, are superb and substantial studies.⁸⁴ Second, there have been a number of studies of Homeric religious practice and the notion of reciprocity that underpins it. Susan Sherratt’s archaeological perspective in ‘Feasting in Homeric Epic’ is important here; and Margo Kitts’ *Sanctified Violence*, Sarah Hitch’s *King of Sacrifice*, and Richard Seaford’s *Reciprocity and Ritual* illustrate how a poet working in this particular epic tradition has adapted his own understanding of religious practice to poetic ends.⁸⁵ On prayer see Simon Pulleyn, *Prayer in Greek Religion*, and on supplication see Kevin Crotty, *The Poetics of Supplication*: these volumes, too, consider religious belief and practice alongside poetic craft.⁸⁶ The third path, a path that brings purely literary approaches to the epics together with their theology, was opened up by Jasper Griffin in 1980, with *Homer on Life and Death*.⁸⁷ Here Griffin reflects on the Homeric gods and the role that they play in the poems--as agents and spectators--vis-à-vis mortals. These and similar themes connected with divine behaviour have since been pursued by other scholars: for example, Naoko Yamagata on the gods’ interest in morality and justice, David Elmer on collective decision-making amongst the gods, Pietro Pucci on the gods of epic and the hero; Ruth Scodel on the important distinctions between *moira* (fate) and

the plan of Zeus, and the significance of these in the poem, especially with regard to the figure of Zeus.⁸⁸ These topics—the gods, their unreliable defence of justice, and their sublime inscrutability--continue to absorb scholars of the epics.

Primary Sources

The essential reading for the study of the Homeric religion and religious practice is the epics themselves. The standard edition of the *Iliad* and also the *Odyssey* is that of D.B. Monro and T.W. Allen (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 3rd edn, 4 vols, 1920). A detailed Anglophone commentary on the Greek text of the *Iliad* is the series of volumes under the general editorship of G. Kirk (*The Iliad: A Commentary* [Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 6 vols, 1985-1993]); a comparable commentary on the *Odyssey* (published originally in Italian) has been edited by A. Heubeck et al. (*A Commentary on Homer's Odyssey* [Oxford: Clarendon Press, 3 vols, 1990-1992]).

There are abundant translations of the poems into English and other languages, particularly of the *Iliad*. Recommended English translations of the *Iliad* are the verse translations of R. Lattimore (*The Iliad of Homer* [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1951]) and R. Merrill (*The Iliad: Homer* [Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2007]) and the fine prose translation of M. Hammond (*The Iliad: A New Prose Translation* [Harmondsworth: Penguin Books, 1987]). Of translations of the *Odyssey*, those of Lattimore (*The Odyssey of Homer* [New York: Harper and Row, 1965]), W. Fitzgerald (*The Odyssey: Homer* [London: William Heinemann, 1962]), and, most recently, E. Wilson (*The Odyssey: Homer* [New York: W.W. Norton, 2018]) have much merit. All are verse translations.

A useful reference work on all aspects of the Homeric epics, including all aspects of Homeric religion, is M. Finkelberg, *The Homer Encyclopedia* (Chichester: Wiley Blackwell, 3 vols, 2011).

Further Reading List

Bachvarova, M., *From Hittite to Homer: The Anatolian Background of Ancient Greek Epic* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016), chapters 10, 11 and 13.

Bremmer, J., 'The Greek Gods in the Twentieth Century', in J. Bremmer and A. Erskine (eds), *The Gods of Ancient Greece: Identities and Transformations* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2010), 1-18.

Burkert, W., *Griechische Religion der archaischen und klassischen Epoche* (Stuttgart: Kohlhammer, 1977); *Greek Religion: Archaic and Classical*, trans. John Raffan (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1985).

Burkert, W., *The Orientalizing Revolution: Near Eastern Influence on Greek Culture in the Early Archaic Age*, trans. M. Pinder and W. Burkert (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1992).

Crotty, K., *The Poetics of Supplication: Homer's Iliad and Odyssey* (Ithaca and London: Cornell University Press, 1994).

- Eidinow, E. and J. Kindt, *The Oxford Handbook of Ancient Greek Religion* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2015).
- Gould, J., 'On Making Sense of Greek Religion', in *Myth, Ritual Memory, and Exchange: Essays in Greek Literature and Culture* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001), 203-234.
- Griffin, J., *Homer on Life and Death* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1980), chapters 5 and 6.
- Hitch, S., *King of Sacrifice: Ritual and Royal Authority in the Iliad* (Washington, D.C.: Center for Hellenic Studies, 2009).
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- Sherratt, S., 'Feasting in Homeric Epic', in J. Wright (ed.), *The Mycenaean Feast* (Princeton: American School of Classical Studies at Athens, 2004), 181-217.
- Vernant, J.-P., 'Mortals and Immortals: The Body of the Divine', in F. Zeitlin (ed.), *Mortals and Immortals: Collected Essays / Jean-Pierre Vernant* (Princeton NJ: Princeton University Press, 1992), 27-49.
- West, M., *The East Face of Helicon: West Asiatic Elements in Greek Poetry and Myth* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1997).
- West, M., *Indo-European Poetry and Myth* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007).
- Yamagata, N., *Homeric Morality* (Leiden: Brill, 1994).

Notes

¹ Hesiod, by contrast, in his *Theogony*, which dates to a similar period, offers us an account of the origin of the world and the birth of the gods and their generations. Although distinct from the epic genre, this too was a traditional genre with a long history: on Hesiod and the Theogony, see M. West, *Hesiod: Theogony* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1966) 1-16.

² For the contribution of scholars working with Linear B material, see S. Hiller, 'Mycenaean Religion and Cult', in Y. Duhoux and A. Morpurgo Davies, *A Companion to Linear B: Mycenaean Greek Texts and their World* vol. 2 (Louvain-la-Neuve: Peeters, 2011), 169-211 (for his conclusions: 203-208); for the contributions of scholars working with Near Eastern material, see W. Burkert, *The Orientalizing Revolution: Near Eastern Influence on Greek Culture in the Early Archaic Age*, trans. M. Pinder and W. Burkert (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1992), 9-33, 114-120; M. West, *The East Face of Helicon: West Asiatic Elements in Greek Poetry and Myth* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1997); *Indo-European Poetry and Myth* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007); S. Morris, 'Homer and the Near East', in I. Morris and B. Powell (eds), *A New Companion to Homer* (Leiden: Brill, 1997), 599-623.

³ R. Martin, 'Epic', in E. Eidinow and J. Kindt (eds), *The Oxford Handbook of Ancient Greek Religion* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2015), 152.

⁴ On these qualities cf. J.-P. Vernant, 'Mortals and Immortals: The Body of the Divine', in F. Zeitlin (ed.), *Mortals and Immortals: Collected Essays / Jean-Pierre Vernant* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1992), 27-49. Even Hephaestus, the lame god, is powerful in every other way (*Il.*18.474-477). For a rich account of Near Eastern parallels to the portrayal of the gods in Homeric epic: West, *The East Face of Helicon*, ch. 3 *passim*; *Indo-European Poetry and Myth*, ch. 3 *passim*.

⁵ See, e.g., J. Chadwick, *The Mycenaean World* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1976), 86-87.

⁶ Cf. Indic *Dyaus piter*; and Latin *Diespiter*, *Juppiter*: W. Burkert, *Greek Religion: Archaic and Classical*, trans. J. Raffan (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1985), 125-126; West, *Indo-European Poetry and Myth*, 166-167.

⁷ Chadwick, *Mycenaean World*, 86; Burkert, *Greek Religion*, 10, 16-18.

⁸ Burkert, *Greek Religion*, 119-189; *Orientalizing Revolution*, 14-25; J. Bremmer, 'The Greek Gods in the Twentieth Century', in J. Bremmer and A. Erskine (eds) *The Gods of Ancient Greece* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2010), 1-18, at 1-7.

⁹ G. Kirk, 'The Homeric Gods: Prior Considerations', in G. Kirk (ed.), *The Iliad: A Commentary* vol. 2 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990), 1-14, at 2, 6. Aphrodite and Apollo are 'conspicuously absent' from the Linear B tablets: Hiller, 'Religion and Cult', 183.

¹⁰ See Eur. *Bacchae*, 64-166, for the suggestion that the god's rites have emerged from Phrygia. Dionysian rites are recognized in the *Iliad* (22.460); but the god himself does not appear in the narrative.

¹¹ Chadwick, *Mycenaean World*, 84-99; on Aphrodite's late arrival, see West, *Indo-European Poetry and Myth*, 186.

¹³ Burkert, *Greek Religion*, 125-126; West, *Indo-European Poetry and Myth*, 167-168.

¹⁴ Burkert, *Greek Religion*, 121-122.

¹⁵ E.g. μῶλυ, at *Od.*10.305: on what are claimed to be remnants of a divine language, see E. Minchin, 'The Words of Gods: Divine Discourse in Homer's *Iliad*', in A. Lardinois, J. Blok, M. van der Poel (eds), *Sacred Words: Orality, Literacy and Religion* (Leiden: Brill, 2011), 17-18.

¹⁶ Cf. Herodotus' well-known claim at 2.53; and see too J. Gould, 'On Making Sense of Greek Religion', in J. Gould (ed.), *Myth, Ritual Memory, and Exchange* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001), 227: '[h]is gods behave for the most part as men . . . '.

¹⁷ See further Burkert, *Greek Religion*, 218; cf. Kirk, 'The Homeric Gods', at 4-5.

¹⁸ Burkert, *Greek Religion*, 129.

¹⁹ Burkert, *Greek Religion*, 130.

²⁰ As is Calypso, as she laments at *Od.*5.118-144.

²¹ Chadwick, *Mycenaean World*, 98.

²² The assembly of the gods is a motif well established in the Semitic literatures of the Near East: West, *Indo-European Poetry and Myth*, 150-151.

²³ Poseidon at Onchestus (*Il.*2.506); at Helice and Aegae (*Il.*8.203-204); at Pylos (*Od.*3.4-6, 43-44); Aphrodite at Paphos on Cyprus (*Od.*8.362-363); Apollo at Chryse, Cilla, and Tenedos (*Il.*1.37-39); Delos (*Od.*6.162-163); Delphi (*Od.*8.79-81); Ismarus (*Od.*9.196-201); and Ithaca (*Od.*20.276-278); and Hera at Argos, Mycenae, and Sparta (*Il.*4.51-54).

²⁴ J. Griffin, *Homer on Life and Death* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1980), 184. On festivals in both the Mycenaean and the archaic Greek world: M. Bachvarova, *From Hittite to Homer: The Anatolian Background of Ancient Greek Epic* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016), 226-236. On the sacrificial feast (δαίτη) celebrated in honour of Poseidon at Pylos see *Od.*3.43-48.

²⁶ For Near Eastern parallels: West, *The East Face of Helicon*, 181-185; *Indo-European Poetry and Myth*, 132-134. For further discussion, see below.

²⁷ Griffin, *Homer on Life and Death*, 179-204.

²⁸ For Zeus' pity for mortals see *Il.*8.245; 17.648; 22.169-172; for discussion of occasions when gods are motivated by moral concerns, see below.

²⁹ Griffin, *Homer on Life and Death*, 190; B. Graziosi, 'Theologies of the Family in Homer and Hesiod', in E. Eidinow, J. Kindt, and R. Osborne (eds), *Theologies of Ancient Greek Religion* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016), 53-54.

³⁰ On supernatural explanations for departures from normal behaviour in epic poetry and in life, see E. Dodds, *The Greeks and the Irrational* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1956), 1-27; on the duplication of motivation, see 14. It is not always the case that human behaviour is divinely motivated: Agamemnon's behaviour at *Il.*1.22-325 is all his own.

³¹ For valuable discussion: R. Scodel, 'Homeric Fate, Homeric Poetics', in C. Tsagalis and A. Markantonatos (eds), *The Winnowing Oar. New Perspectives in Homeric Studies* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2017), 77-95.

³² Translations from the Homeric poems are drawn from R. Lattimore (trans.), *The Iliad of Homer* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1951/1961); *The Odyssey of Homer* (New York: Harper Perennial, 1965/1991).

³³ For Homeric use of *aisa* (a 'measure of one's life'), see, for example, *Il.*1.416; 24.224; *Od.*11.61). *Moirai* is often, but not always, synonymous with death: e.g. *Il.*4.517, 6.488, 22.303; *Od.*2.99-100; 11.558-560. For extended discussion: N. Yamagata, *Homeric Morality* (Leiden: Brill, 1994), 105-120.

³⁴ This idea, that each of us has an allotted portion of life spun out for us at birth, is very old: it is a necessary response, familiar to us even today, to the harshness of human existence: R. Janko, 'Free will, fate and the gods', in R. Janko (ed.), *The Iliad: A Commentary* vol.4 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992), 5.

³⁵ Yamagata, *Homeric Morality*, 120.

³⁶ For further discussion see D. Elmer, *The Poetics of Consent: Collective Decision-Making and the Iliad* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2013), 146-173; on the evocation of pathos through the responses of the gods, see P. Pucci, 'Theology and Poetics in the *Iliad*', *Arethusa* 35 (2002): 17-34.

³⁷ In an earlier scene in the epic, Zeus has considered aloud whether to snatch the Trojan ally Sarpedon out of the fighting, or whether Patroclus should go on to kill him in the contest. Hera rebukes her husband: none of the other gods will approve should he negate Sarpedon's destiny (*Il.*16.440-449). See Yamagata, *Homeric Morality*, 116; Scodel, 'Homeric Fate', 83.

³⁸ Yamagata, *Homeric Morality*, 10-11.

³⁹ This divine function does not attract an epic epithet ('*Horkios*' is the classical term). On oath-making rituals and oath-making violence, see M. Kitts, *Sanctified Violence in Homeric Society* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005); A. Sommerstein and I. Torrance, *Oaths and Swearing in Ancient Greece* (Berlin: de Gruyter, 2014).

⁴⁰ Kirk, *The Iliad: A Commentary* vol. 1, 308; Pucci describes Zeus' action as 'staggeringly ironic': 'Theology and Poetics', 24.

⁴¹ W. Kullmann, 'Gods and Men in the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*', *Harvard Studies in Classical Philology* 89 (1985): 1-23, at 6.

⁴² Yamagata, *Homeric Morality*, 239; West, *Indo-European Poetry and Myth*, 130.

⁴³ Kullmann, 'Gods and Men', 5-7.

⁴⁴ Kullmann, 'Gods and Men', 7-12.

⁴⁵ K. Vlassopoulos, 'Religion in Communities', in Eidinow and Kindt (eds), *The Oxford Handbook of Ancient Greek Religion*, 257-271.

⁴⁶ For honey (perhaps mixed with milk) and water as offerings (to the dead), see *Od.*11.26-28. For parallels with the Mycenaean world, see Hiller, 'Religion and Cult', 176-177, who notes, however, at 207, that 'taken as a whole the outlay for the offerings was on a modest scale'; for Near Eastern parallels: West, *The East Face of Helicon*, 38-42.

⁴⁷ Although one does not expect the poet to state such requirements, it is clear that altars, at least, are a recognized element: e.g., *Il.*1.440, 448; 2.305-306; 24.69-70; *Od.*3.273, 13.185-187; 22.333-337.

⁴⁸ It is possible that Chryses offers these prayers not as priest but as father of the girl in question and recipient of Agamemnon's insulting behaviour.

⁴⁹ For the first use of the terms, see F. van Staten, *Hiera Kala: Animal Sacrifice in Archaic and Classical Greece* (Leiden: Brill, 1995); for the application of the terms in the Homeric context, see S. Hitch, *King of Sacrifice: Ritual and Royal Authority in the Iliad* (Washington DC: Center for Hellenic Studies, 2009), 27-39.

⁵⁰ Hitch, *King of Sacrifice*, 29.

⁵¹ R. Seaford, *Reciprocity and Ritual: Homer and Tragedy in the Developing City-State* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1994), 42-50; Hitch, *King of Sacrifice*, 28-29; and see 37, 151-153 for the suggestion that Homeric practices may look back to the Mycenaean world.

⁵² The sequence moves quickly from the killing of the beast to the preparation of the sacrificial meal: there is no consultation of entrails, particularly the liver, as in later periods: see 'Reading Divine Signs'.

⁵³ M. Detienne, 'Culinary Practices and the Spirit of Sacrifice', in M. Detienne and J.-P. Vernant (eds), *The Cuisine of Sacrifice among the Greeks*, trans. P. Wissing (Chicago: Chicago University Press, 1989), 1-20, at 11.

⁵⁴ F. Naiden, 'Sacrifice', in Eidinow and Kindt (eds), *The Oxford Handbook of Ancient Greek Religion*, 465-467, at 467.

⁵⁵ Seaford, *Reciprocity and Ritual*, 44-47; Hitch, *King of Sacrifice*, 22-25; and, on feasting in the archaeological record, S. Sherratt, 'Feasting in Homeric Epic', in J. Wright (ed.), *The Mycenaean Feast* (Princeton: American School of Classical Studies at Athens, 2004), 181-217.

⁵⁶ Ajax is the sole Iliadic example, at *Il.*7.321-322; and cf. (in a domestic context) Telemachus at *Od.*4.65-66; Demodocus at 8.474-481; Odysseus at 14.437-438.

⁵⁸ Burkert, *Greek Religion*, 70-73.

⁵⁹ S. Pulleyn, *Prayer in Greek Religion* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1997), 12-15, 16-38.

⁶⁰ Seaford, *Reciprocity and Ritual*, 13-29, 65-73.

⁶¹ Cf. the punishment of Oineus (*Il.*9.533-542); and of Menelaus (*Od.*4.466-480).

⁶² Pulleyn, *Prayer*, 16-38, 56-69 (and see 60-62 for evidence from Linear B).

⁶³ On imperatives in prayers: E. Minchin, *Homeric Voices: Discourse, Memory, Gender* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007), 188-203, esp. at 199-200.

⁶⁴ Pulleyn, *Prayer*, 30-31.

⁶⁵ Pulleyn, *Prayer*, 29-30; 56-69: even in these cases the notion of *quid pro quo* may be latent (69).

⁶⁷ 'Epic thereby regulates the religious imagination': Martin, 'Epic', 158; see too J. Morrison, 'The Function and Context of Homeric Prayers: A Narrative Perspective', *Hermes* 119 (1991): 145-157.

⁶⁸ Kullmann, 'Gods and Men', on divine intervention in both epics; and see especially his note (at 3) that this kind of divine behaviour is found also in Near Eastern poetry, from the second millennium BC: see West, *The East Face of Helicon*, 185-190..

⁶⁹ Burkert, *Greek Religion*, 111-112.

⁷⁰ On the division of the cosmos after the defeat of the Titans, and the allocation to Hades of the Underworld, see *Il.*15.187-193. For Near Eastern parallels: West, *The East Face of Helicon*, 151-155.

⁷¹ There is some inconsistency in the Homeric view: at *Od.*24.1-204 the souls of the unbursed suitors are able to speak with the ghosts in the Underworld.

⁷² Antikleia at *Od.*11.155-162, 181-203, 216-224; Agamemnon at 405-434, 441-461; and Ajax at 543-544, 563-564.

⁷³ Zeus, especially, reveals his enormous power, both in his control over the fates of mortals and in his angry responses to his wife: observe the moment of his considered nod of assent to Thetis at *Il.*1.528-530, which shakes all Olympus, or his balancing of the golden scales at 8.68-77, as he watches the fighting on the Trojan Plain, and the thunder and lightning that he sends forth, with which he terrifies all the Achaeans. And see his forceful but measured words to Hera at 15.14-33.

⁷⁴ Three examples suffice: Zeus' teasing of Hera and Athena at *Il.*4.5-19, Athena's sulky reaction (22) and Hera's angry reply (25-29); Hera's crafty persuasion of a number of other gods to aid her in seducing Zeus (14.153-353); Artemis' abuse directed at her brother (21.472-477).

⁷⁵ M. Bowra, *Tradition and Design in the Iliad* (reprint edn Westport: Greenwood Press, 1977), 222, describes them as a 'delightful, gay, invention of poets': J. Redfield, *Nature and Culture in the Iliad: The Tragedy of Hector* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1975), 76, describes the gods as frivolous and unsteady; he sees the gods of the *Iliad* as literary gods. On the question whether the gods of the Homeric poems the gods whom the archaic age would have worshipped: Griffin, *Homer on Life and Death*, 144-145, 148-149; E. Kearns, 'The Gods in the Homeric Epics', in R. Fowler (ed.), *The Cambridge Companion to Homer* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004), 70.

⁷⁶ Griffin, *Homer on Life and Death*, 172, 199.

⁷⁷ What emerges from the *Iliad* is a view of mankind that is both heroic—in the noblest and best sense of the word—and tragic. On 'subordination', see Kearns, 'Gods in the Homeric Epics', 72-73: for Kearns, this is a troubling 'double perspective'.

⁷⁷ On the role of gods as spectators, see Griffin, *Homer on Life and Death*, chs 5 and 6; Pucci, 'Theology and Poetics'.

⁷⁸ Scodel ('Homeric Fate', 92) takes the metapoetic function of the gods even further. In her discussion of the implementation of the Plan of Zeus, she proposes that the problems that Zeus encounters in bringing it to fulfilment represent the difficulties faced by a composer 'in constant negotiation' with the tradition, the audience before him, and his patrons.

⁷⁹ F. Graf, 'Zum Figurenbestand der Ilias: Götter', in J. Latacz (ed.), *Homers Ilias: Gesamtkommentar, Prolegomena* (Munich: K.G. Saur, 2002), 115-132, at 115.

⁸⁰ Kirk, *The Iliad: A Commentary* vol. 2, 9, 13.

⁸¹ Martin, 'Epic', 163.

⁸² For a convenient summary of the type of evidence that Linear B texts can provide, see J. Chadwick, *The Mycenaean World* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1976), ch.6. For more recent and more detailed studies see S. Hiller, 'Mycenaean Religion and Cult', in Y. Duhoux and A. Morpurgo Davies, *A Companion to Linear B: Mycenaean Greek Texts and their World* vol. 2 (Louvain-la-Neuve: Peeters, 2011), 169-211.

⁸³ L. Gernet, *Le génie grec dans la religion* (Paris: Bibliothèque de synthèse historique, 1932); M. Nilsson, *A History of Greek Religion*, trans. F. Fielden, 2nd edn (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1949). For discussion of these earlier scholars' work, see J. Bremmer, 'The Greek Gods in the Twentieth Century', in J. Bremmer and A. Erskine (eds), *The Gods of Ancient Greece: Identities and Transformations* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2010), 1-18.

⁸⁴ S. Morris, 'Homer and the Near East', in I. Morris and B. Powell (eds), *A New Companion to Homer* (Leiden: Brill, 1997), 599-623; M. West, *The East Face of Helicon: West Asiatic Elements in Greek Poetry and Myth* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1997); *Indo-European Poetry and Myth* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007); M. Bachvarova, *From Hittite to Homer: The Anatolian Background of Ancient Greek Epic* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016), chs 10, 11 and 13.

⁸⁵ S. Sherratt, 'Feasting in Homeric Epic', in J. Wright (ed.), *The Mycenaean Feast* (Princeton: American School of Classical Studies at Athens, 2004), 181-217; M. Kitts, *Sanctified Violence in Homeric Society: Oath-Making Rituals and Narratives in the Iliad* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005); S. Hitch, *King of Sacrifice: Ritual and Royal Authority in the Iliad* (Washington, D.C.: Center for Hellenic Studies, 2009); R. Seaford, *Reciprocity and Ritual: Homer and Tragedy in the Developing City-State* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1994).

⁸⁶ S. Pulleyn, *Prayer in Greek Religion* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1997); K. Crotty, *The Poetics of Supplication: Homer's Iliad and Odyssey* (Ithaca and London: Cornell University Press, 1994).

⁸⁷ J. Griffin, *Homer on Life and Death* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1980), chs 5 and 6.

⁸⁸ N. Yamagata, *Homeric Morality* (Leiden: Brill, 1994); D. Elmer, *The Poetics of Consent: Collective Decision-Making and the Iliad* (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 2013), ch. 7; P. Pucci, 'Theology and Poetics in the Iliad', *Arethusa* 35 (2002): 17-34; R. Scodel, 'Homeric Fate, Homeric Poetics', in C. Tsagalis and A. Markantonatos (eds), *The Winnowing Oar. New Perspectives in Homeric Studies* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2017), 77-95.